

Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn Statements (internal, RU only)

[all (supplementary) materials are included or linked from here including teaching portfolio]

Sunday 16th August, 2026 13:23

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1 Research

I am in the field of social indicators, quality of life, wellbeing, and life satisfaction. The main journals are Applied Research in Quality of Life (ARIQ) and Social Indicators Research (SIR).¹ I am on the editorial boards of both. The main academic/professional organization is International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS). ARIQ may be less known across social sciences than SIR, but it is the flagship journal of ISQOLS. My field is thinner on theory than other social science, (post-)positivist, and quantitative—about patterns, relationships, and effects—but rather correlational than causal. (Quasi-)experiments are very rare, and there are more descriptions and visualizations than economics and statistics. My field is somewhere between geography, sociology, psychology, and philosophy.²

All research is (supposed to be) new in some sense, but my research is more original/innovative than most. Many contribute only incrementally, say by slightly improving a model, adding an interaction or instrumental variables. My contribution is new ideas—human creativity is important in current AI age. I have creative ideas, and then able to find the right data to test them. I was the first to look at several relationships:³ energy use→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), social v individual religiosity→happiness across countries (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010) and →trust in the US (Valente and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2021), religiosity→creativity across space (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015b), and person v society level politics→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014).

¹Journal of Happiness Studies has shifted towards positive psychology and happiness economics.

²Geography is a notable part of it—my research intersects with geography: regions, and especially urban-rural gradient. This is a subjective description of the field, or rather sub-field, and this is where I fit. There are other sub-fields, notably positive psychology and happiness economics—they are related but different in important ways. My field is well described by its pioneer, Alex Michalos: Michalos (2014b,a).

³In quantitative way, focusing on and elaborating the relationship (not just listing among others or controlling for it). You will see in my many papers that the idea is indeed the first of its kind—nobody has looked at the relationship before in this way.

My main area of research has been urban-rural happiness gradient, a term coined in my early paper on the topic: “An urban-rural happiness gradient” (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). This line of research is not entirely new—it has been studied in a quantitative fashion in a limited way in the 70s and philosophically since antiquity—but mine are the first studies in modern times.⁴ And I have a related line of research looking at livability of places: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2013a), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2019a).

My urban-rural happiness gradient research includes careful gradient elaboration (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017) and theory-rich Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis (2018). As the research has matured, I added: generational differences (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019b), adolescence (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2020), panel data (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), elaborated happiness measurement (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2024), and Covid19's effect (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026). Finally, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) shows that urban unhappiness is common across countries.

I work with students to explore the gradient further: examined population change instead of level (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), and turned to non-WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies: India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

I am at the forefront of the urban-rural happiness debate.⁵ Some may argue that happiness has little to do with public policy and administration—nothing further from the truth.⁶

Near-future trajectory remains similar: mostly urban-rural happiness gradient and regional happiness, adding Latin American focus (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). I plan to spend more time on grant writing to grow my research group, hire students and post-docs, and do course buy-outs.⁷

Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1, higher than the top journal in public administration in the US,⁸ *Public Administration Review* with IF=7.2.⁹ Since 2017 I have also published 4 articles in *Social Indicators Research*, and 9 in *Applied Research in Quality of Life*, both leading/main journals in my field. I am also collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus), and my citations more than tripled (Scopus) or more than doubled (Google Scholar) since 2017. See details and more metrics in Appendix: “Scientometrics” section.

2 Teaching (teaching portfolio)¹⁰

Something I have dreaded as a student, and promised myself I won't do on the other side as an instructor. Style over substance: prioritizing appearance, aesthetics, and presentation over actual quality, meaning, and functionality—it looks and sounds impressive but lacks value, real utility—just like much of social science prose (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2013b). Instruction is unnecessarily fluffy and ornamented, often grandiose as if the goal is to put student in a sense of awe (Dawkins 2004). The problem seems especially acute in political science and public policy and administration.

⁴There is a 30-40 year generational gap between mostly 70s and very few in early 80s versus my first study in 2009.

⁵For instance see the discussion in framing essay IV in Edited by Pia Heike Johansen and Fisker (2022). Likewise the literature has picked on “energy-happiness paradox”—the term that I have coined (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), for instance see: Nasrudin et al. (2022), Park et al. (2025), Bakehe et al. (2026), Du and Zhang (2025). And I was just added (June 2026) to the editorial board of *Applied Research in Quality of Life* journal: “Dear Adam, We are therefore pleased to invite you to serve on the editorial review board of ARQOL. You stand out as a top candidate given your excellent work and expertise on quality of life. [...] We consider Editorial Review Board members as guardians of the academic quality of the journal and trusted advisors to the editorial team.”

⁶See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are clear policy implications of my work, for instance see (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015a, Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden 2017). My numerous *Cities* papers have dedicated takeaways for policy/practice section, e.g., see recent (Mikhaeil et al. 2024, Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

⁷My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation. And currently, I spend more time on http://pivot.proquest.com/funding_opps/ and scheduled coffee with Thomas S. Risch, Camden Vice Chancellor for Research, while I am working now on NSF grant proposal: <https://www.nsf.gov/funding/opportunities/isp-infrastructure-systems-people>

⁸I am in a department of public policy and administration in the US.

⁹<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=16956&tip=sid> and <https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=17167&tip=sid>

¹⁰This section together with teaching appendix in this document serve as my teaching portfolio—see additional details in appendix. For a list of classes that I teach see CV.

Now as an instructor I skip the fluff and cut to the chase—convey practical information efficiently. Usefulness/utility is the key. Learning by doing, no memorizing—for instance, students bring their own data and we apply skills and tools learned in the class to the data, no exams. When I was a student I was forced to memorize theory and formulas and read hundreds of pages of formal texts. But I wasn't taught how to use the skills and the tools. I condense the material, make it relevant, maximize utility/usefulness with minimum effort, focus on what's most important in most accessible practical hands on way.¹¹

I decrease instruction and increase interaction: discussions, presentations, “flip the class,”¹² and extra labs in addition to the class. Such interactive social approach seems even more important in current reality: short attention span, information overload, AI, and mental health problems. We need to connect, be at ease, have good energy, and even some fun in class—it shouldn't be tedious and gruesome, at least not all of it. It is not watering down the curriculum. I provide plenty of extra/bonus materials so that it is customized to a student, doesn't overwhelm with unnecessary stuff, but provides enough depth and individual learning path. Pleasant learning experience matters, but so do outcomes.

I want my teaching to produce results. Learning (motivation, too) is the direct result. But then comes transfer of knowledge, ability to apply that learned information. We need results either in academia or outside of it.

I have supervised 9 dissertations (5 in-progress). Four PhDs have graduated, and all have a job. One is at SIPRI (Stockholm International Peace Research Institute), a think-tank ranked 11th or 31st worldwide.¹³ Another one at Virginia Tech and the other 2 were employed at Rutgers when graduated. My students publish. Since 2020, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities with Impact* Factor of 8.1.

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes not only work in the academic research, but also in the real world: “The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job [...] I greatly appreciate it.” and “subject: Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.” and “since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, [...] I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.”

I try to guide students individually, in the grand scheme of things, teaching is about helping students become who they are, and everyone is little different. This is another reason for forcing less required material and making more available as bonus/extra for self-actualization. I make sure I am available and approachable for students spending extra time outside of classroom: working on papers, being accessible via zoom and in person, including when on sabbatical.¹⁴

A final point on my teaching philosophy. I support public/civic service/engagement in my teaching. All my classes encourage (but not force) and give extra credit for it. And I support students even after the class in their civic endeavors—see service section. But this is not activism, it is evidence based, data driven analysis and problem-solving. It is rather positivist “what is,” than normative “what should be,”¹⁵ I support in my teaching old fashioned critical thinking, and I don't believe classroom is a place for political indoctrination of the students. I'm (post-)positivist in my teaching—I encourage students to try to get closer to the objective truth through evidence and data. Activism and political action are better left to politicians.

I concluded my teaching philosophy, now turning to technicalities. One highlight is unusually heavy curriculum development. Since

¹¹Students appreciate my teaching style, e.g., “left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style” and “Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!”

¹²Work on projects and homework collaboratively in class as opposed to home as done traditionally.

¹³<https://thinktankalert.com/rankings> and <https://guides.library.upenn.edu/c.php?g=1035991&p=7509972>

¹⁴Now in Spring 2026 I am on sabbatical, but I still have 4 students enrolled in my dissertation hours, working with another one informally on dissertation (starting formally in Fall) and I work with other students on papers informally (“summer research” projects not enrolled formally in a class).

¹⁵Similar to Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration (NASPAA) competency: “to analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make decisions.” Invariably, some activism creeps in—the challenge is to unlearn what students “learn” in some other classes. And some forms of activism as in “policy implications” may be useful as long as it is kept to the minimum and follows from actual research and is evidence based.

coming to Rutgers-Camden in 2012, I have taught over 10 different classes, developed from scratch most of them, including 3 courses in 2023 for our new data science program. I am updating my teaching materials each time I teach a class, and I am working on my teaching materials relatively continuously—for instance my visualization class has been updated over 200 times over past 3 years: <https://github.com/theaok/vis/commits/main/>¹⁶

I teach, mentor, and support students from different programs. In my home department of public policy and administration (DPPA), I teach regularly in Masters of Public Administration (MPA) and MS and PhD in Public Affairs, but I also teach regularly students from MS in Data science in my always cross listed DPPA courses. Often there are also few PhDs from Prevention Science, and occasionally masters students from other departments such as Psychology, and Criminology and Sociology.

I strive to improve my teaching: I attended cybersecurity training,¹⁷ and 2024 Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on "Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus." In 2026 attended OTEAR RU "Developing a Teaching Portfolio" (Virtual Interactive Workshop), and 2 RU-Camden IDT webinars "Teaching in Zoom: Best practices" and "Communicating with students: Best practices"¹⁸ And I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on nature.com, chronicle.com, insidehighered.com, and others.

My teaching strength and preference is data science classes, but also happiness class that aligns with my research. I have been also developing a new class "social indicators" that would be broader than just happiness and include topics such as trust, freedom, and meaning. This would also align with my editorial position at Social Indicators Research journal.

I am interested in teaching short courses / micro-credentials. I have already taught a short GIS course twice (<https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/>), informally, for my colleagues from the department and other faculty from Arts and Sciences, and for Walter Rand Institute. But I would like to teach more often and other short courses. There are Micro-credentials and Digital Badges that I would like to participate in.

I am 2025 recipient of department's Jay A Sigler award for "outstanding service and dedication to students" (awarded by students); the plaque says "this award is given to the faculty member who exhibits a commitment to student's academic development and personal growth."

3 Service

My service mostly builds on and derives from my main focus and strength, research. I provide such service in two main ways: 1) to the profession/scholarly field, and 2) to students.

I review papers for journals, 4-5/mo or 48-60/year as of May 2026, including the top journals such as Journal of Personality and Social Psychology and Public Administration Review (see CV for details). Reviewing is an essential foundation of scholarly fields, and increasingly in short supply—something I can attest to as a journal editor. Since January 2024, I co-edit Social Indicators Research, the leading journal in my field of quality of life and wellbeing. My editorial philosophy is to be mentor and helper, not just gate-keeper—for instance, I am often in favor of revision prior to external review (instead of desk-reject), and I try to guide the authors, especially the junior ones.¹⁹

My research-oriented service over past 6 years 2020-2026 to students is: published 10 peer-reviewed articles with students as co-authors, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science

¹⁶Most GitHub pushes are small incremental updates and cosmetic fixes, still >200 pushes is a considerable volume of updates. The point is that I put effort to revise, update, upgrade, extend, etc the teaching materials frequently. (Still I do take long multi-week breaks for research only).

¹⁷2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

¹⁸<https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/83839> and https://ru-stream.rutgers.edu/media/Teaching+in+ZoomA+Best+practices/1_hdw4elan; https://ru-stream.rutgers.edu/media/Communicating+with+studentsA+Best+practices/1_ujifqspb and https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1u9wL-G0Acsv8nhvHzYlkaArCqAN2ojAQkm1Bx9Bx1hY/edit?slide=id.g537a443357_0_3#slide=id.g537a443357_0_3.

¹⁹I am grateful to the editor of Journal of Applied Psychology who has guided me when I was a junior author.

master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social science, and supervised 15 independent studies. I have also led brown bag seminars and organized a workshop on academic publishing.

And I am very excited about bringing to campus an award winning²⁰ junior professor from Germany as a visiting scholar for 2 months in Fall 2026: Leonie C. Steckermeier. Leonie is a productive scholar already benefiting 2 of our doctoral students—we have monthly or so zoom meetings where we are already working on papers.

I contribute service to the campus and department. Over 2018-2022 I have lead the development of a new MS in data science and associated certificate program. This was a substantial undertaking and also somewhat challenging as the newly created programs are located outside of my home department. I have been serving since 2022 as a director for data science certificate.²¹ I have just supervised 2 courtesy appointments as volunteer researchers in DPPA—they have worked with me on research but also helped students in my class. I frequently serve as either ad hoc chair or member on Advancement and Promotions (A&P) committee. I find this service fulfilling. I contribute to promoting quality faculty in our social sciences and I learn about my colleagues. Other committee service is enumerated in the CV. As I have been taking on more leadership roles²² I have realized I need also skills in project management, so I have just completed a project management course by Google on Coursera.

While research-oriented service is my strength and passion, and usual campus and departmental service is my duty, I am also mindful of Rutgers-Camden public/community service/engagement mission. I agree that as a public university, we also need to engage with and provide service to the public and community. I have assisted a number of Rutgers-Camden students in their community projects over past 5 years serving as a faculty advisor for, for instance: Olorunfunmi Adebajo's internship at the Camden County Community Development Office's Homelessness Assistance Unit,²³ Marlo Rossi's project at Walter Rand Institute and other projects on abortion,²⁴ and Ojobo Agbo Eje: "Camden Health Equity Data Visualization Initiative."²⁵

New Jersey first, but I have been civically engaged outside of the Garden State as well. For instance, I have used my data management skills to assist with data collection and management for Ohio Business Round Table, and Michigan Economic Competitiveness Study.

In the ideal world, I would like to continue with research-oriented service. In particular, I would like to increase my research group²⁶ and co-author more with students, and ideally postdocs. Chairing dissertations and leading independent studies would be also my strength and preference. I'm happy to take on more administrative duties such as editing another journal or being a graduate director for our PhD program.

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²⁰Publications: <https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=xjkPIhwAAAAJ&hl=de>. Awards: ISQOLS Prize for the Best Dissertation on Quality of Life, Well being, and Happiness, 2nd prize, 2023; Best PhD Dissertation of the Faculty of Human Sciences, Dissertation Award of the Otto von Guericke University Magdeburg for outstanding research achievements in the context of the dissertation, 2022; Second prize of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation for the best social science paper in German for the article "Eine Krise der sozialen Anerkennung? Ergebnisse einer Bevölkerungsbefragung zu Alltagserfahrungen der Wert- und Geringschätzung in Deutschland.", 2019

²¹See certificates at the bottom of the page: <https://graduateschool1.camden.rutgers.edu/graduate-programs>

²²Leading new MS in Data Science development, Polish National Science Foundation grant and associated team leadership, leading a research team of data scientists, hosting a visiting professor and leading an associated research team of PhD students, leading dissertations, master theses, independent studies, papers with students, community projects, and co-editing a journal, among others.

²³News item: <https://patimes.org/from-research-to-county-strategy-how-negative-learning-shaped-camden-countys-shared-housing-innovation>

²⁴News item: <https://theconversation.com/abortion-laws-show-that-public-policy-doesnt-always-line-up-with-public-opinion-274699>

²⁵News item: <https://camden.rutgers.edu/news/rutgers-camdens-urban-innovation-fund-fuels-transformative-community-projects>

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